

Bagels on Sunday

DAVID A. MOROWITZ

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One pleasant ritual of my relatively uncomplicated life is the Sunday morning purchase of freshly baked bagels, a happy task repeated with undiminished delight. And why not? The bagels are wonderful, and the bakery is filled with an animated friendly crowd in lines growing out the door onto the sidewalk. Children perched on their father's shoulders are gnawing their small, moistened samples; everyone is smiling. The morning's hunger is forgotten briefly, and the relaxed weekend decisions are about matters of poppy seeds, onion, garlic, and sesame.

Personifying an earlier, gentler Brooklyn, the baker stuffs a bag with my breakfast, but he dispenses more than his fragrant, chewy circles. Like an archangel weighing souls, he seems to know us all, selling, alongside his food, some of the evidence of our lives he quietly accrues. To him, the customer busily choosing three dozen bagels is likely to host a brunch; the more sedate patron ordering only two or three will probably return to an empty house and a table for one. Some of his former couples now shop separately. A few pay with hundred dollar bills, others with coins.

But the cash register's musical staccato dismisses melancholy. For here are commerce, good smells, suburban cheerfulness, and health, mixed among kids, the young, the very old, and the in-betweens. Owing to the uniform excellence of what is baked here, most of us are regulars. The eight o'clock crowd reconvenes punctually, as do the late risers, both with a light-hearted sense of anticipatory pleasure. And as the angst of late Sunday and the Monday to come have not yet descended, conversations are about car pools, home remodeling, vacations, and colleges. Warm, bagged bagels under their arms, the exiting customers smile at the rest of us, affirming the worth of the wait.

But like a slowly expanding dark spot in the shaving mirror I face each morning is the sense, occurring more frequently with age, of how fragile are the good fortunes of all of us in that particular time and place. Waiting in turn, I find myself wondering which of us will be the first absentee on some future Sunday, sensing also the miracle of our weekend reunions. Everybody here seems to have enough money, gets into a car that works, is not short of breath from the walk into the bakery, and exhibits neither pain nor anxiety that might require an analgesic or a tranquilizer. For all of us here at the bakery have managed to avoid or survive life's historical, medical, or psychiatric catastrophes and, in doing so,

seem blissfully forgetful of how closely we approach them each day.

While not part of the turbulence in a happy shop on Sunday, the tragic possibilities may be just offstage, imaginable as the tiny margins by which we escape them. Leave your driveway onto the street a bit too early, and you will be crushed by a speeding truck; a first morning's urine is combined with blood, and your life's closure is made visible in a toilet bowl. Or perhaps, it's a phone call that finds you at four in the morning and begins with the words, "This is Officer . . ."

For all of us buyers of bagels, seemingly numbed by the noisy happiness, that day hasn't yet come. Our coughs have all managed to disappear; the reassuring sound of regular breath only inches away still warms our awakenings. Unexplained weight loss reverses, and the bad news, seeming to come out of nowhere, goes to someone else. We haven't yet lost in life's reverse lottery.

Life, companionship, health, solvency: these are gifts none of us fully understands. But shouldn't we at least sense the wondrousness of the luck involved? A half-second of travel may be all that separates a safe arrival from death in traffic. An extra millimeter in a coronary artery's size defers a heart attack for forty years. But for some antique good fortune, we suburbanites, awaiting our baked goods, might have been placed into an earlier line at Treblinka. We are blessed, but only for now.

Like an unwelcome, persistent insect, the thought of it may be brushed repeatedly from our consciousness, but the Sunday will come when we can't operate a car, count our change, or sense the simple, almost mindless prospect of starting coffee and separating out the sections of the morning paper. The short trip for our bagels ought to be seasoned with gratitude: for each future errand, for the life and health they represent, and for our nonchalance in forgetting temporarily that this cannot last, not even an act so small and perfect as going for bagels on Sunday.

I want to say to the fathers with kids on their shoulders, to the housewives returning to their station wagons, to all those wearers of designer jeans, to please look hard—drink in the beauty of the commonplace. Know your immense good fortune. We skate on ice whose thinness we never fully appreciate until our ankles chill as we crash through it. The bagel encircles the thin middle of our hourglass.

On these happy Sunday mornings I wonder what my children will look like when their hair, which I will not live to see, turns white. To know its impermanence can only make us love this life more. Going for bagels on Sunday is fate's temporary indulgence, the exultation of the ordinary.

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